

DESCEND FROM 30

Art brief for contracting artists

A 2D side-scrolling roguelike (Godot 4.6). Survivors descend a 30-floor apartment building during a zombie outbreak, scavenging apartments and fighting through corridors, floor by floor, to the lobby. One playthrough is three characters (a morning, an afternoon and a night run) through the same building as it decays. Everything plays on a single flat walking plane; the camera scrolls left and right.

Tone: “cozy horror”

Warm, lived-in apartments turned dangerous. The dread comes mostly from atmosphere, light and decay, but blood and gore are welcome as an element where a scene earns it (a mauled corpse, a blood-slick floor, a spatter up a wall). Grounded, slightly muted palette; strong, readable silhouettes. The title art below is the mood target.

Art style: open

Pixel art is one good fit but NOT the only one. A painterly / cartoon full-art style would suit this vibe just as well, for example Valiant Hearts: The Great War. Pitch whichever style you are strongest in; what matters is the tone and readability set out here, not the medium. (The current placeholders happen to be pixel art.)

Scope at a glance

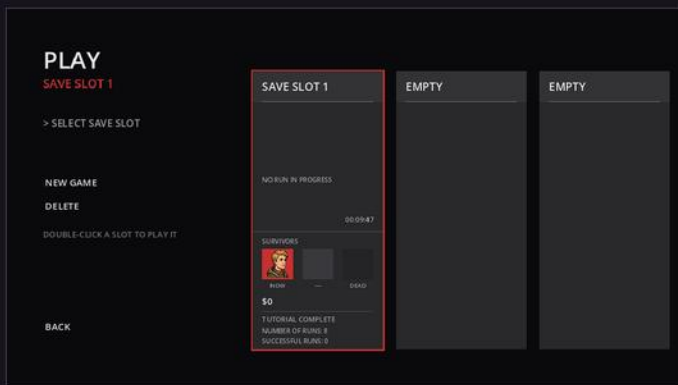
This is a full game art package, not a one-off: player character sprites (multiple survivors), enemy sprites, NPCs, inventory and in-world items, environments (varied corridors, modular rooms, stairwells, elevator, lobby), UI and HUD, and player health-state portraits. Sections below break each down.



Title screen: the tone and mood we are aiming for.

Where it is today

Current build with placeholder art (what you would be replacing or adding to). These are quick flavour scenes, shown small for reference.



Save-slot / Play menu: UI style + survivor portraits (three runs per save).



Controls / Settings: UI style, list rows, rebind buttons.



Run 1 (Morning): corridor combat. Bright daytime, healthy portrait, sword equipped. The colourful blocky figure is the PLACEHOLDER player.



Run 2 (Afternoon): a modular apartment room (Bathroom). Wounded portrait, gun equipped, a broken weapon greyed in the hotbar.



Merchant floor: trades from the elevator. Note the warm ceiling light cones (engine lighting), the wall fire-extinguisher, and a corpse on the floor.

Critical conventions (read first, these prevent re-work)

- ONE FEET BASELINE. Every character and enemy stands on the same floor line. Author each sheet so the character's FEET sit at a fixed row in the frame, identical across all frames and all characters; tell us that feet offset. (Our placeholder rigs were authored at different scales and paddings, so their drawn feet don't line up: the #1 thing to fix.)
- AUTHOR ART FLAT / NEUTRALLY LIT: the engine does the lighting. The game adds REAL dynamic 2D lighting on top (warm lamp pools, fire glow, cool moonlight, darkness). So no baked hard highlights or cast shadows on characters or props (a soft contact-shadow under the feet is welcome). Every asset must still read when the only light on it is a single warm pool in a near-black room (night).
- AUTHOR FACING RIGHT: the engine mirrors for left. Avoid asymmetric details that break when flipped.
- MEDIUM: pixel art OR painterly / cartoon full-art are both welcome. If pixel, keep it pixel-perfect (integer frames, nearest-neighbour, crisp edges). If full-art, deliver clean high-resolution art with transparent backgrounds; we scale to fit.
- Transparent background, no baked scenery inside a character sheet.

Scale & density

- The game renders at 1152x648. Standard humanoids read about 90-110 px tall on screen; deliver at a comfortable native size plus the intended in-game scale and we scale to fit.
- Bigger creatures are TALLER, not lower; feet still on the same floor line.

- **CONSISTENT CHARACTER HEIGHT** (important, a live gameplay issue): today's PLACEHOLDER player reads only about 56 px tall while the zombies are 84-99 px, so the player is the odd one out and tall enemies (Long Arm, Spitter) tower, their attacks reading as passing over the player's head. New art must fix this: the player and a standard zombie should stand at **ROUGHLY** the same height, with attack reach at a matching level; bigger types (Big) are taller but proportioned so their hits still land. All feet on the shared baseline.

Characters & enemies

Placeholder rigs shown at true in-game scale, feet aligned.



Five enemies. They currently SHARE one rig (reskins), so we need **DISTINCT** silhouettes: the Standard zombie; the Big (a larger, heavier zombie with a heavy attack); the Crawler (low, dragging along the ground); the Long Arm (extended reach); and the Spitter (ranged, with a spit projectile). Each needs idle, walk or move, attack, hit or stagger, death.



The four poses above are stills; the placeholder player rig **ALSO** already includes full attack animation sheets (melee swing and gun shoot) and the walk / run / crouch / hurt / death cycles, all available as reference for timing and frame counts.

- **Player**: full set. Idle, walk, run, crouch-idle/walk, scavenge, melee attack, gun (idle/walk/run/shoot), hurt, death, door-approach and knock, balcony rope-lash and climb.
- **Enemies**: Standard, Big (larger, heavy attack), Crawler, Long Arm, Spitter.
- **NPCs**: the Merchant already exists in-game (trades from inside the elevator car); **MORE** NPCs will need designing later (e.g. a barricade-keeper survivor, and others as the story grows).

Player health stages

The character visibly deteriorates as they take damage.



Six HUD portrait states, Healthy to Dying (shown bottom-left of the HUD). These are **TEMPORARY** and show **ONE** player character. We plan **MULTIPLE** playable characters, male and female body types, up to about 8 potential survivors, and **EACH** needs the same six health-state portraits (escalating

injury, blood and exhaustion) plus its own full body sprite set. Match this progression per character.

Environment & modular rooms

- Corridor / hallway set: wall, baseboard/trim, ceiling, floor, WITH VARIETY. The player descends 30 floors; the corridor must NOT feel like the same background 30 times. We need several corridor variants (layout, decor, wear) plus immersion differences so each stretch feels distinct as you go down (this is separate from the top-to-bottom decay below).
- Apartment doors BY STATE: closed, open, locked, weak/damaged, barricaded, breached.
- Stairwells (an up flight and a dark down shaft); windows (stairwell and apartment balcony, daylight and moonlight come through these).
- Elevator (corridor doors and the interior car), maintenance room (workbench, fuse box), lobby, and the floor-30 hallway.
- MODULAR apartment rooms: bedroom, kitchen, bathroom, study, living room, dining room; each a self-contained ~320 px-wide module (three sit side by side per apartment), furnished for scavenging (see the Bathroom shot). Same anti-repetition rule: a FEW variations per room type, not the same bathroom every time.
- Props: crate-stack barricade, corpse, world-drop pickups, keys, wall fire-extinguisher.

Sectional identity: the descent DECAYS (a key pillar)

The infection is worst at the bottom, so the building should visibly rot the lower you go. Deliver corridor and door (ideally room-dressing) variants across three bands:

- Floors 30-21 (top): clean, intact, lived-in.
- Floors 20-11 (mid): disturbed, damage, blood, disorder, breaking down.
- Floors 10-1 and the lobby (bottom): grotesque, heavy infection growth, corruption, ruin.

Time of day

The ENGINE lights and tints each run dynamically, so author art once, neutrally lit.

- MORNING (run 1): bright daytime. Near-fully lit, minimal shadow, art reads at true colour and the dynamic lighting barely intrudes (see the Morning shot).
- AFTERNOON (run 2): a cooler dusk. Warm interior light pools begin to matter against a colder fill; the cozy-horror contrast starts here (see the Afternoon shot).
- NIGHT (run 3): NOT YET FINAL (in development, no shippable night scene to show). Target: near-black corridors lit ONLY by lamp pools, fire, moonlight through windows, and the player's faint aura. Enemies lurk unseen in the dark until you are on them (jump-scares). Deep dread, the building at its most hostile. We want art that survives this: readable in a single warm pool, sinister in shadow.

Because the engine handles the light, do NOT deliver separate day and night versions of an asset unless we ask; one neutral version is lit three ways.

Items & UI

We also need ITEM art: inventory icons and in-world pickups (weapons, tools, medical, food, junk, keys, cash, and so on), readable at small HUD size. There are about 36 items; a full per-item spec exists on our side and we will share it when we get to this. For now, just flagging that item design is part of the scope.

And UI: the HUD (portrait frame, hotbar slots, floor and mode readouts) and menu screens (title, save-slots, settings), see the shots on page 2 for the current placeholder style. A cohesive UI pass is part of the package.

Deliverables & naming

- Clean art with transparent backgrounds. Sprite sheets as horizontal strips (one animation per row) or per-file frames; be consistent and tell us the layout.
- Per animation: name, frame count, frame size, suggested fps, loop or one-shot, feet offset.
- Naming: subject_anim.png, e.g. player_walk.png, zombie_standard_attack.png, door_barricaded.png, corridor_wall_mid.png.
- FIRST: a palette / style swatch and one "hero" mock of a lit corridor with a character, so we can lock the look before full sets.